suggested my father leave immediately for Ramgarh to find out what had transpired.

Brigadier Bhagat was to later author the famous Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report that remains classified even today despite successive governments being in power. The report was a detailed study commissioned by Army Headquarters to document the events of October-November 1962 in NEFA but eventually its mandate was limited to commenting on the military reasons for the newly raised IV Corps' defeat. However, at the time, the Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report was yet to be written; my father, when he returned from Ramgarh, went to the commandant's house and briefed him about what he had seen and heard in Ramgarh. He told him about the haunted looks in the eyes of those who had survived, the smell of decay, every little bit of information… As he sat listening, Bhagat had tears in his eyes. India's senior-most Victoria Cross holder, like so many of his countrymen, could not take the humiliation. By then one thing was evident —life, for all of us, young or old, would never be the same again.

♦

Since then, regardless of where one went, the shadow of 1962 was never very far away. In the early years, not yet familiar with the area, I had no idea of what the terrain looked like or what the situation on the ground really must have been like. Different people left different impressions, but as I grew up, I found myself listening to each and every word that was spoken by the survivors of the conflict and by those who constantly analysed it. I stored away every bit of information that I could lay my hands on.

In 1979 my father was a lieutenant colonel posted in the Cabinet Secretariat in Army HQ in Delhi. We were living in the multi-storeyed apartment blocks on Sardar Patel Marg next to where the Taj Palace hotel would come up subsequently. An elevator with an attendant would ferry people up and down through the day. For a few days, we couldn't help but notice a particular attendant who would always look at my father with a shy half smile. But apart from wishing him very respectfully he would never say anything else. In his early fifties, lean and gaunt, he had the erect bearing of a soldier. The man walked with some difficulty, for he would shuffle away with the help of a walking stick at the end of his shift. A few